

IAS PRELIMS/MAINS

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SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY



A COMPREHENSIVE COVERAGE

MODULE - 21

INFORMATION & COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGY (ICT) - 2

NET NEUTRALITY

INTRODUCTION

- The internet has become such an integral part of our lives that we want it to be free and open.
- We want internet to be a place where we can always access any lawful content we want and the people who are delivering the content can't play favorites because they disagree with the message being delivered or want to charge more money for faster delivery.



NET NEUTRALITY

1 WHAT IS THE PROBLEM?

- When we send or receive data over internet, we expect the Internet Service Provider (ISP) to transfer that data from one end of the network to the other. We don't expect them to read it or manipulate it.
- ISPs have technologies that allow them to scrutinize every piece of information we send or receive online.
 - ✓ **Example:**
 - ❖ the websites we visit
 - ❖ videos we watch
 - ❖ internet phone calls or
 - ❖ the data generated by using social media.
- ISPs can use their technologies to interfere with the data flow by slowing down or blocking traffic and websites they don't like or speeding up the traffic they like or the ones that pay them.



NET NEUTRALITY

2

WHY WILL THE ISPS INTERFERE WITH THE DATA?

- The reasons can be:
 - ✓ Profits and other corporate interests.
 - ✓ Dislike for certain political viewpoints etc.
 - ✓ Companies might interfere with content that makes them look bad.
 - ✓ Block websites of their competitors or
 - ✓ To make profits by forcing website owners to pay more to avoid having their data blocked or slowed down.



NET NEUTRALITY

3 WONT COMPETITION PREVENT THEM FROM DOING THIS?

- It should, but it is not happening.
- Firstly, the manipulations of our data are not always easily detectable. Content can be delayed or distorted in different ways difficult to detect.
- Second, there are not more than a handful of legitimate, high speed and reliable broadband options at home. And it costs many millions to build a big high speed broadband service so the 'barriers to entry' to the market are high. That means customers often cannot switch if a big broadband provider starts manipulating their data.



NET NEUTRALITY

4 WHAT IS NET NEUTRALITY?

- Net Neutrality means applying well established 'common carrier rules' to the internet in order to preserve its freedom and openness.
- Such rules prohibit the ISP from discriminating against information by halting, slowing or tampering with the transfer of data, except for legitimate network management purposes like easing congestion or blocking spam.

COMMON CARRIER

- A common carrier provides services to the general public for public convenience and necessity, without discriminating.
- Example: Public airlines, public buses, phone companies, taxicab companies etc.



NET NEUTRALITY

- Net Neutrality is not only a consumer issue but it is also one of the foremost free speech issues of our time.
- Our free speech rights must be protected both online and offline. After all, the freedom of speech and expression is not worth much if the forums where people make use of it are not themselves free.



NET NEUTRALITY

DEFINITION - 1

- Net Neutrality is the principle that ISPs treat all data on the internet equally and do not discriminate or charge differently by user, content, website or platform. Under this principle, ISPs are unable to intentionally block, slow down or charge money for specific content or websites.
- If this principle is not enforced, ISPs will start selling the internet in bundles.
 - ✓ Example: for accessing social media sites like FB, Twitter, Instagram etc, a separate package will be sold, for some other websites some other package will be sold.

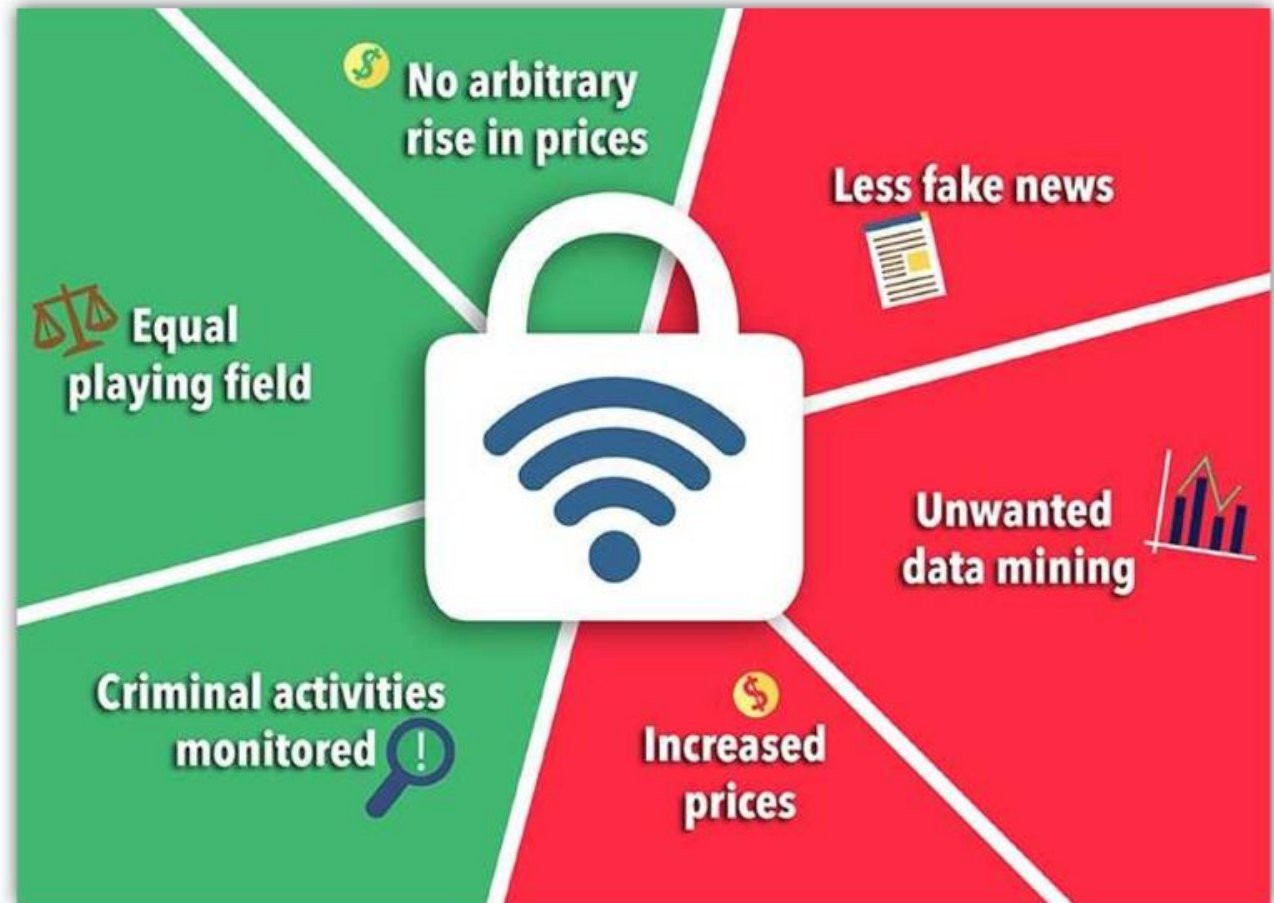
DEFINITION - 2

Net Neutrality means that governments and ISPs treat all data on the internet equally and do not differentially charge consumers for higher quality delivery or giving preferential treatment to certain websites.



WHAT ARE THE CONCERNS OF SMALL WEBSITES AND START-UPS?

- If there is no net neutrality then industry giants could pay ISPs to get advantage and this would leave the small businesses on unfair playing field.
- Net Neutrality is ensuring that consumer choice is not influenced by differential ease or cost of access for internet services. It means equal business opportunity for all businesses and that the ISP doesn't create any discrimination between them.



PRINCIPLES OF NET NEUTRALITY

■ The basic principles of net neutrality are:

1. All websites must be equally accessible:

- ✓ The ISPs should not block certain sites just because they don't pay them.
- ✓ They should also not create any gateways which influence discovery of sites, giving preference to some sites over the other.
- ✓ The basic idea is 'you don't want your Internet access to become as limited as your cable TV service.'

2. All websites must be accessible at the same speed:

- ✓ This means no speeding up of certain sites because of business deals. More importantly it means no slowing down some sites.

3. The cost of access must be the same for all the websites: It means no Zero Rating.



ZERO RATING

- It is the practice of not charging customers for data use on specific websites.
- Zero Rating is criticized for the following reasons:
 - a) It provides a way to ISPs to create 'walled gardens' which favours their own and affiliate content.
 - b) It negatively affects privacy as ISPs do scrutiny to determine if users are on zero rated sites and disallow them to venture beyond such sites.
 - c) It is anti-competitive and anti-innovative favouring established sites that can pay to be zero rated.

**DON'T LET
THE PEOPLE
WHO
PROVIDE
THE
INTERNET
DESTROY
THE
INTERNET.**



NET NEUTRALITY

- So by keeping net neutral, we are:
 1. Allowing consumers to pick winners but not ISPs. By making net neutral the consumer's experience will not be influenced by how the ISP differentiates between the businesses. Consumers are likely to pick services that are accessible, faster and affordable. Making services available, fast and cheap must be in the hands of businesses but not the ISPs.
 2. Allowing businesses to compete on a level playing field.



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Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588